



THE 365 CIRCLE: C-SUITE ADVANTAGE

LEADERSHIP

SPOTLIGHT

He Did Not Choose the Safest Path. He Chose the Most Ancient One. And It Led Everywhere

"Alchemy is not turning base metal into gold as someone else defines gold. It is finding what gold means for you. That is the whole journey."

INDIAN KNOWLEDGE SYSTEMS, DHARMIC ENTERPRISE DESIGN | 20+ YEARS TRANSFORMING BUSINESSES AND MINDS

VINAY KULKARNI

FOUNDER, ALCHMI



EDITOR'S OPENING

The Homecoming That Wasn't One

There is a familiar version of the returning-Indian story. It has been told often enough to harden into cliché.

A professional builds a career abroad, comes home with healthier savings and a sharper résumé, and slots neatly into a senior role in an industry they already know. Vinay Kulkarni is not that story.

He came back after fifteen years in the United States to find that the India he had carried in his memory had not waited for him. The schooling was still Macaulayan. People thought in binaries, in tidy categories. His daughter — whom he had brought home to grow up in the country of her heritage — was surrounded by an India that somehow felt more American than the America he had left.

That small, personal observation became the seed of everything he has built since. Not a consultancy. Not a startup. A system. A way of seeing. A working ecosystem of institutions, businesses, academies, retreats, a bookstore, a bistro, and a research lab — all pointed at one question: what changes when you run a business, a classroom, a family, or a life from the inside of an old framework rather than the outside of a new one?

He calls it **dharmic enterprise**. He has been circling the idea, under different names, since he was a boy buying Swami Vivekananda pamphlets for two rupees apiece at a Ramakrishna Ashram. This is the story of a man who spent twenty years learning to ask the right question — and now teaches others to do the same.



ROOTS

A Member of Three Libraries at Once

The Reading Life

Vinay grew up middle-class in Bengaluru, shaped less by any one school or mentor than by an appetite that refused to sit still. He held cards at three libraries at the same time — the Indian Institute of World Culture, the City Central Library, and a third whose name he has half-forgotten. He read his way through thousands of books: O. Henry and Roald Dahl, the Pañcatantra and the Mahābhārata, the Amar Chitra Katha and the Kathāsaritsāgara, biographies of anyone who had lived more than one life at a time.

The Mastermind of the Mind

He built what he later called a mastermind of the mind. We do not get to choose where we are born, or to whom, he reasoned — but in the inner world we can keep any company we like. So he kept the best. Vivekananda became his first doorway into the spiritual life. One line from Lincoln stayed for good: the surest way to defeat an enemy is to make a friend of him.

The Sanskrit Years

From his Sanskrit years — he studied the language from the eighth to the twelfth grade and still recites verses his classmates have long forgotten — one subhāṣita anchored his moral compass: the rare person who does good through thought, word, and deed, yet treats the smallest kindness shown to him as if it were the size of a mountain, and remembers it every day with gratitude.

The Trains

He studied between Bengaluru and Mysore, three hours each way, and treated every carriage as an unscripted classroom. He never knew who would be sitting across from him — what trade they practised, what life they had lived — so he asked, and listened, and read each stranger like a book.

"I was a member of three libraries at the same time. Every person I met on the train was a book I hadn't read yet."

He Arrived at Senge Without Knowing the Name

Vinay reached the United States carrying the intellectual furniture of a Bengaluru boyhood and a mind already wired for systems thinking — before he had a word for it.

His master's thesis, written without reference to any particular management thinker, was about systems thinking and mental models. His advisor read it and said: *this is Peter Senge*. Vinay asked who that was. Senge's *The Fifth Discipline*, he was told, was among the most influential business books ever written — and it drew on the Bhagavad Gītā, on Krishna's teaching of non-doership. Without meaning to, Vinay had walked to the same ground by a different road.

That convergence — an ancient Indian teaching meeting the most respected systems framework in Western business literature — stayed with him. It was the first proof that what he had always sensed was not parochial. It was universal.

Creative Head — 15to25.com

Leading a cross-functional team of designers, developers, and writers. Early training in design thinking and editorial craft.

COO — Arizona

Chief Operating Officer of Arizona's largest residential and commercial relocation company. Full ownership of P&L, operations, sales, marketing, IT, and finance; positioned the company for acquisition by Suddath.

Senior Advisor & Director of Product Strategy

Strategy and transformational change for companies from five million to five hundred million dollars in revenue. Enterprise B2B product strategy for a global platform.

The Convergence

"My advisor said: this is Peter Senge. I'd arrived at *The Fifth Discipline* without knowing it existed. That told me the old frameworks weren't regional. They were pointing at something universal."

Breadth as Method

The career that followed was wide on purpose. Breadth, in his case, was never restlessness. It was the same instinct as the libraries and the trains: read everything, model everything, keep the lesson.

At the End of My Own Intelligence



The Reckoning

Vinay does not describe his pivotal moment as a failure. He describes it as an honest reckoning with what the modern mind, left to itself, can produce. It was 2008. He had spent years building real expertise across strategy, consulting, operations, marketing, and e-commerce.



The Cry Out

He had delivered for clients. He had the credentials, the frameworks, the track record. And then he arrived, with unusual clarity, at the edge of what his own intelligence could offer — facing problems too large for the tools he had. He asked the universe for a guide.



The Meeting

Six months on, flying back to India after fifteen years away, he had a premonition — before it happened — that he was about to meet someone who mattered. He met his guru. The initiation that followed opened dimensions he had not had access to.



Becoming a Receiver

He frames the shift structurally. The work, from then on, was to receive without distortion — to become, as his guru described it, a flute through which something larger plays, with no "me" left in the way. He carries this lightly. He does not preach it. He simply builds from it.

"I felt I'd reached the end of my own intelligence, and the problems in front of me were bigger than I could handle. So I asked the universe for a guide. Six months later, I met him."



THE FOUNDING

Why He Named It Alchmi

Back in India, Vinay founded Alchmi — first in the San Francisco Bay Area, then rooted in Bengaluru. The name comes from alchemy: turning something ordinary into something extraordinary, not as the world defines it, but as the thing itself defines it once it has done the honest work of finding out what it actually is. Alongside it he built e-Com Elephant, a full-service e-commerce design, build, and operations practice serving businesses across India.

What set Alchmi apart from ordinary consulting was the lens. The most common problem he found in a business was rarely operational. It was a quiet misalignment between purpose and structure — a company optimising hard for a destination it had never actually chosen.

The moment a founder accepts that stress is simply the price of running a business, the journey turns into that miserable train ride that only pays off at some far-off IPO. Alchmi asks a more uncomfortable question first: is the destination itself even the right one?



Alchmi

Strategy consulting built on business alchemy and the Dharmic Enterprise Framework.



e-Com Elephant

Full-service e-commerce design, build, and operations serving businesses across India.

"When I came back, I found India had vanished — and that I'd arrived at a more American version of India than America itself. I thought: this has to be addressed."





THE ECOSYSTEM

Most Founders Build a Company. He Builds Systems.

When the question of what India needed grew concrete enough to act on, Vinay did not start with a single company. He started with the problem and let the institutions grow out of it, one answer at a time.



Sanskritishaala

Cultural workshops for children and parents, built on creative pedagogies and games designed to change mental models rather than merely transmit information — and summer camps that give children access to their own heritage.



Sanathani

An Indic merchandise brand, so that families can buy products carrying their own stories instead of borrowed ones. Even Superman, he likes to point out, owes a quiet debt to Hanuman.



Upadesha Academy

Immersive, experiential workshops led by serious practitioners in business, management, music, dance, Sanskrit, nutrition, psychology, and meditation.



Darshana Books & Gifts

A curated bookstore carrying the best of the Indian knowledge traditions, alongside crafts, artefacts, and gifts — a counterweight to shelves stocked almost entirely with one worldview.



Samvada Bistro

A food space where Indian and continental dishes are made with real attention to food science and nutrition. Food, he points out, is never neutral: Italy conquered us without sending a single soldier — it simply exported pizza.



Shastra Research Lab

A place to test concepts from the old texts through contemporary inquiry — where the ancient and the empirical can meet without apology.

The Alchemy of a Space

Vinay is precise about what he was after when he brought Upadesha Academy, Darshana Books, Samvada Bistro, and a meditation room together under one roof in Bengaluru. He wanted a place where the architecture, the books, the food, the people, and the very quality of attention all pointed in the same direction — a place where someone could meet the Indian knowledge systems through a meal, a book, an overheard conversation, or a half-hour of silence. The Blue Zones — those rare pockets of the world where people routinely live past a hundred — share no single diet or climate, he notes; what they share is community. He set out to build one.

The word upadeśa carries the weight of the design. It means the crystallised wisdom of the ṛṣis, handed on without distortion. And it comes with an obligation: you do not merely receive such knowledge as a consumer who paid and left. If you were fortunate enough to understand any of it, you take on the duty to pass it on. People come, they learn, and they leave as carriers, not just customers.

In a recent session for thirty entrepreneurs, he walked the room through a reflection process built around a question most of them had never been asked directly: what business are you actually in — and what problem did the universe choose you to solve? As Adjunct Faculty at the RV Institute of Management, he reaches between 180 and 360 MBA students at a time, in courses built on Indian knowledge systems applied to real management questions. They are, he says with quiet satisfaction, loving it.

Upadeśa

The crystallised wisdom of the ṛṣis, handed on without distortion. You do not merely receive such knowledge as a consumer who paid and left — you take on the duty to pass it on.

Community as Design

The Blue Zones share no single diet or climate. What they share is community. He set out to build one.

"I wanted a place where the moment you walk in, you start to feel calm — not because we told you to, but because everything in it points the same way. That's the alchemy of a space."



Dharma, Artha, Kāma, Mokṣa

Vinay's case for Indian Knowledge Systems in business is not cultural nostalgia. It is a structural argument, and he makes it with the precision of someone trained in both worlds. The old framework names four aims of a human life, and his point is simple: modern business runs on two of them and quietly deletes the other two.

Artha

Wealth — the one metric most modern frameworks optimise for. Necessary, but incomplete on its own.

Kāma

Desire — the motivation to build. Modern strategy is powered almost entirely by kāma. But desire without a guiding frame turns from creation into extraction.

Dharma

The harmonising principle — that which sustains the individual, the family, the society, the planet. The frame that makes growth compatible with well-being.

Mokṣa

Freedom — from external constraint, and from the false self that wealth and desire, left unguided, inevitably build. The dimension edited out of the modern picture entirely.

The structural gap follows directly. When a framework operates only on artha and kāma, sustainability can only ever show up as a product feature, a marketing line, or a compliance box — never as a civilisational principle. His diagnostic tool, the Dharmic Enterprise Framework, runs a company's customer service, sales, marketing, product development, structure, leadership, and management through the dharmic lens. At every stage the question is not *is this efficient?* It is: *is this in harmony?*

"Modern frameworks teach you artha and kāma — wealth and desire. Dharma and mokṣa have been edited out. Then we wonder why every system is unsustainable. The thing is missing two of its four legs."

- i His reference point is precedent, not faith. Total Quality Management came out of Japan and changed how the whole world makes things. Dharmic Enterprise, he argues, could be the next great idea the East exports — a way of building that the West will eventually want.



THE KNOWLEDGE

Indian Knowledge Systems Is Not Religion

Whenever Vinay talks about Indian Knowledge Systems, he heads off the most common misunderstanding first: this is not religion. The four Vedas, the four Upavedas — Āyurveda among them — the Vedāṅgas, the Purāṇas, the Upaniṣads: he reads these not as devotional documents but as one of the most complete bodies of human inquiry ever assembled — into what is real, what a human life is for, and how that purpose can be lived in every dimension at once.



Āyurveda

Personalised medicine that contemporary research is steadily validating — an ancient inquiry into the human body that meets modern science on its own terms.



Material Mastery

The iron pillar at Mehrauli has stood without rusting for some fifteen hundred years. India produced nine grades of steel, including the wootz steel that became the Damascus blade.



Abhyudaya & Niḥśreyasa

Worldly flourishing and spiritual progress, pursued in parallel rather than traded against each other. A civilisation that kept one eye on the visible and the other on the invisible.



Counterfeit Sustainability

A company that disrupts an already sustainable way of life and replaces it with on-demand delivery has not become sustainable by switching to recyclable packaging. The tradition has a precise word for this: adharma.

AI Can Make You Faster — Toward the Wrong Place

Vinay's view of technology is not sceptical; it is precise. He has nothing against AI, platforms, digital tools, or the pace of modern innovation. The Dharmic Enterprise Framework applies to a technology company exactly as it does to any other. The question is never whether the product is clever. It is whether the problem it solves is real and correctly defined, and whether solving it creates genuine well-being for everyone it touches rather than well-being for one at the expense of the rest.

His worry is about direction, not speed. A person spends years in an education unaligned with their purpose, enters a working life unaligned with that education, and keeps an inner life divorced from both — several contradictory selves running at once. Technology pours fuel on all of it, because it accelerates motion without touching direction.

"AI can move you faster. But if you don't know your svadharma — what you're here to do and to be — faster isn't better. You'll just reach the wrong destination more efficiently."

- The founders who come to Alchmi often arrive with a dissatisfaction they cannot name. The business works. The metrics look right. And still the journey feels like that miserable train. His prescription is unfashionable and durable: define your svadharma before you define your growth strategy. The result is not slower growth. It is growth that finally feels like it belongs to you.



The Cows of Goa

Ask Vinay who he is without his company or his title, and he does not reach for credentials. He tells a story instead.

At a meditation camp in Goa, he made himself a promise: he would not eat until he had fed someone else. He was hungry. He went looking for people to feed and found, instead, a herd of cows. He bought every banana and every vegetable in the first shop he could find and fed them. More cows came. He went to a second shop and bought it out too. Then the bulls arrived. He fed them as well. The whole thing took four or five hours. When he finally returned to his room, the meditation that evening was the deepest he had ever known.

"I fed every cow I could find, and I came back with no hunger left. The sages weren't being poetic. They were describing a mechanism: you give, and you're replenished. I've tested it. It's true."

That, for him, is the whole argument in miniature — the joy of giving outweighing, by every measure that matters, the satisfaction of accumulating. Away from the boardroom he teaches MBA students, designs T-shirts printed with the words of the sages, invents dishes, runs children's summer camps, and writes essays that arrive, as he describes them, as gifts out of meditation rather than outputs of a content calendar.

His Idea of Retirement

Not a place. A state of being — free of what he calls the self-made prisons of the modern mind. He wants to live so fully inside his svadharma that the question of who he is without his company never even arises, because it was never the company that defined him.

A Novel Unfinished

He is, by his own account, a novel that has not yet been fully read.

"Enlightenment is never for the person. It is from the person. The day you're free of the self you constructed is the day you find out who you actually are."

No Time to Hedge

Two or three seconds a question. He rarely needed them.

One word for your work today?

Dharma.

Strategy or intuition?

Intuition.

Ancient wisdom or modern frameworks?

There's no conflict between the two.

Profit or purpose?

Profit with purpose.

Build fast or build consciously?

Build consciously, and you grow at a rate that stays sustainable and harmonious for everyone.

The biggest misconception about Indian knowledge?

That it has anything to do with religion.

A daily practice you never skip?

Connecting to the source.

Meditation or execution?

Never execute without meditating.

India's biggest opportunity?

To understand what India actually is — and from there, to guide the world.

"India is the last hope of the planet — because Indian thought is the only knowledge truly aligned with the way nature actually works."

One concept from Indian Knowledge Systems for every leader?

Live your svadharma.

From a Library Card to a Dharmic Ecosystem

Bengaluru, the early years

A middle-class childhood. Three library memberships at once, train journeys to Mysore and back, Sanskrit from the eighth to the twelfth grade, Vivekananda at two rupees a pamphlet. A systems thinker forms — without yet knowing that is what he is.

The master's thesis

Work on systems thinking and mental models that his advisor recognises, unprompted, as Peter Senge. The first confirmation that the old Indic frameworks and the best of Western management thought point at the same territory.

COO — Arizona

Chief Operating Officer of Arizona's largest residential and commercial relocation company. Full ownership of P&L, operations, sales, marketing, IT, and finance; positions the company for acquisition by Suddath.

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First role — 15to25.com

Creative Head of a youth portal, leading a cross-functional team of designers, developers, and content creators. Early training in design thinking and editorial craft.

Senior advisor

Strategy and transformational change for companies from five million to five hundred million dollars in revenue, with deep work in post-merger integration.

Director of Product Strategy

Enterprise B2B product strategy for a global platform.



From a Turning Point to a Dharmic Ecosystem

2008 — the turning point

Reaches the edge of what his own intelligence can offer and asks the universe for a guide. Six months later, on a return journey to India, he meets his guru. A spiritual initiation reshapes everything that follows.

e-Com Elephant

A full-service e-commerce design, build, and operations practice serving businesses across India.

RV Institute of Management

Adjunct Faculty, designing and teaching MBA courses grounded in Indian knowledge systems, dharmic enterprise design, and systems thinking. Reaches 180 to 360 students. They love it.

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Founding Alchmi

Returns to India and founds Alchmi, a strategy consulting practice built on the idea of business alchemy. Begins developing the Dharmic Enterprise Framework.

The ecosystem

In quick succession: Sanskritishaala, Sanathani, Upadesha Academy, Darshana Books & Gifts, Samvada Bistro, and Shastra Research Lab. Several institutions, one direction.



Who Are You When the Title Is Taken Away?

Vinay's advice to the next generation of founders and leaders does not begin with a market insight or a product strategy. It begins with a question. Picture a recent leadership gathering in Toronto, where a moderator asked forty or fifty senior executives to introduce themselves — without naming their company or their title. Nine in ten faltered. Their identity had been outsourced, completely, to a role that will not outlast them. That trap is exactly what he wants the next generation to see coming.

1

Find your svadharma first

Discovering what you are authentically here to do is not a detour from success. It is the precondition for it. The founders who build something that lasts are the ones whose purpose and work are aligned — and that alignment never happens by accident. It takes the kind of deep reflection most professional cultures quietly discourage. Make the time anyway.

2

Stop treating the journey as misery

The miserable train ride is a choice, not a law of nature. The uncertainty, the friction, the setbacks — all of it can be lived as the thing itself rather than as the obstacle to some future reward. That only becomes possible once you genuinely believe the problem you have chosen is worth solving.

3

Become a receiver before you become a doer

The quality of your thinking depends on how clearly you can receive, not how loudly you can transmit. Build stillness into the work; never execute without first reflecting. Keep a mastermind of the mind — the books, mentors, and lives you choose to keep company with shape what you are able to notice. Carry gratitude as a discipline, and the world keeps handing you teachers.

"A real guru never sets out to become a guru. India's opportunity is to understand what India actually is — and from that understanding, to help the rest of the world."